

Question 2 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Describe the evolution of Human Resource Development from traditional employee training to a strategic organisational function.

Answer

HRD evolved from welfare and training activities into a strategic function linked to business goals, culture and competitive advantage.

- 1. Welfare and personnel era:** Early industrial organisations emphasised welfare, discipline, record-keeping and industrial relations. Development of people was incidental.
- 2. Training as a discrete activity:** After World War II and with scientific management, organisations ran job-skill training. Learning was short-term, job-specific and often isolated from strategy.
- 3. Nadler's HRD concept (1969):** Leonard Nadler introduced HRD as organised learning for behavioural change, widening the field beyond classroom instruction to development and education.
- 4. T.V. Rao and Indian HRD movement:** In India, HRD was institutionalised as a system of appraisal, feedback, potential appraisal, career planning, training and OD, especially after the 1970s–80s.
- 5. From maintenance to development:** HRM remained largely maintenance-oriented (staffing, compensation, IR). HRD became development-oriented, focusing on competence, climate and culture.
- 6. Integration with organisational strategy:** Later, HRD was expected to support change, quality, technology and global competition. Training needs, career paths and talent pipelines were aligned with strategy.
- 7. Strategic HRD:** Today HRD includes competency mapping, leadership pipelines, learning organisations, knowledge management and human capital. HRD professionals advise top management on capability building.
- 8. Line-manager partnership:** Evolution also shifted responsibility from the training cell alone to all managers, making development a shared strategic duty.

Conclusion. *The journey from isolated training to strategic HRD reflects the recognition that people capability is a core source of organisational effectiveness and long-term survival.*